

"Rapid-Impact Interventions": How a Policy of Integrated Control for Africa's Neglected Tropical Diseases Could Benefit the Poor

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Over the past two decades there have been significant achievements in the control of a handful of important human tropical infections [1]. These achievements include the substantive reductions in the prevalence and incidence of the so-called neglected diseases such as lymphatic filariasis, onchocerciasis, guinea worm, leprosy, and trachoma (Box 1) [2]. Each of these neglected diseases is a poverty-promoting and often stigmatizing condition occurring primarily in rural areas of low-income countries (Box 2) [3]. They are ancient afflictions, described in the Bible and other ancient texts, which have burdened humanity for millennia [3]. But now, as a result of aggressive regional vertical interventions, there is a possibility that some neglected tropical infections could be eventually controlled to the point of elimination in some areas of endemicity [2-8]. In the case of guinea worm infection, disease eradication might also soon be possible [9].

Box 2. Common Features of the Neglected Tropical Diseases

Ancient afflictions that have burdened humanity for centuries

Poverty-promoting conditions Associated with stigma

Rural areas of low-income countries and fragile states

No commercial markets for products that target these diseases

Interventions, when applied, have a history of success